

Koala

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Source: `Koala -- Claire Saxby\_ illustrated by Julie Vivas.pdf` (32 PDF pages; story on PDF pages 6-26, about-page 28, index 29)

Prepared: 9 September 2026

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In a high tree fork, a gray ball unfurls. Tall as a toddler, a sleepy young koala sniffs at leaves. His nose is dark and leathery. His soft ears twitch, and his brown eyes blink. He has two extra thumbs, and paws perfect for climbing. Climb, little Koala. It's dinnertime.

Koala is thirsty and nuzzles at his mother's pouch. But for the first time, Koala cannot make his way in.

Koalas eat the leaves of only a few of the many types of eucalyptus trees. These leaves are poisonous to most animals.

When he tries again, his mother swats him away.

Koalas are marsupials and suckle their young in a pouch. Baby koalas are called joeys.

He climbs beyond her reach, takes a mouthful of leaves, and chews slowly. Climb, little Koala. It's time to find your own way.

Once a koala is pregnant again, she will ignore her joey. Young koalas must look after themselves from then on, though they may stay close by for another year.

In the night, Koala startles from his sleep-curl as a roar tears the air. It is louder than a snoring grandfather, closer than thunder. In his waking panic, Koala reaches for his mother. But she is not there.

The thundering koala, another male, pushes at him. Koala tumble-climbs to the ground. He scrambles back to his home tree, but before he can reach the first branches, the male rumbles again. Move on, little Koala. Find a new home.

From late spring to the end of summer, male koalas search for mates. They fight any other male koalas they meet. These fights are always noisy and can be violent.

Koala retreats, uncertain and unsafe on the ground. He listens to earth sounds, then sniffs at the base of a large eucalypt. The bark stinks. It is a warning -- stay away!

Mature male koalas have a scent gland on their chest. They rub against the bark at the base of a tree to claim it as their own.

Koala has never been to this part of the forest before. He searches and listens, sniffs and hesitates. Koala climbs, but the bark is loose, and he falls.

He climbs again, more slowly this time. He fills his cheek pouches with leaves to chew later.

Koalas avoid the new tips of eucalypts, as they can be poisonous. Growing koalas need to eat around 10 ounces (300 grams) of leaves every day. Fully grown koalas eat even more. These leaves need a lot of chewing.

Koala travels farther and farther from his mother. He eats when he can and sleeps where he can. Move on, little Koala. Find a new home.

Several koalas may share the same forest but will seldom share a tree. Koalas mostly live alone except when seeking a mate.

One wild night, the wind grows until even the tallest tree sways like a sapling. Koala clings tight, safe and warm as raindrops plomp and plit around him.

Koalas can sleep through even fierce storms. Their thick, oily fur acts like a rain jacket, keeping them dry even in heavy rain.

It is dawn before the storm is done. In the pale morning, Koala spies a large stand of trees beyond a clearing. As he touches the ground, a snake uncoils in the leaf litter. Koala startles and launches himself across the clearing, reaching with his front paws, jumping with his hind legs. Faster, little Koala, faster.

When koalas move slowly, they use all four limbs in turn, but if they are in a hurry, they hop with their hind legs together, like kangaroos.

Only when he is far above the ground does Koala stop and look around. He sees other koalas, but they are not too close. Koala eats until he is full. A breeze gentles his fur, and he shifts. Stay, little Koala. This will be a good home.

Koalas are found only in Australia. They are marsupials, or pouched mammals, and live in trees. They can sleep up to eighteen hours a day. Their waking time is spent eating and grooming. In northern Australia, male koalas weigh up to 20 pounds (9 kilograms) and have light-gray coats. Koalas in the south have darker coats and are larger, with males weighing up to 30 pounds (14 kilograms). In both the north and south, females are smaller than males. Koalas generally remain in a small home range. Females may stay in the same small area for their lifetime, moving only if they run out of food. Males may have to roam farther in search of a mate.

Removed from the story flow during cleanup (book prose preserved word for word; page refs are PDF pages):

- PDF pages 7-8 (vision-verified 9 Sept 2026): page 7 is an illustration-only spread with no text; page 8 (print p. 8) reads "Koala is thirsty and nuzzles at his mother's pouch. But for the first time, Koala cannot make his way in." -- now in the story flow above.
- Page 25 hurrying-koalas side panel (vision-verified 9 Sept 2026): "When koalas move slowly, they use all four limbs in turn, but if they are in a hurry, they hop with their hind legs together, like kangaroos." -- now in the story flow above, placed after the clearing-dash paragraph (print p. 24) per print order.
- The opening spreads show the gray ball unfurling in the high tree fork, the sniffing, twitching, blinking close observation, and the mother's swat (per prose cues; not pixel-verified).
- The middle spreads show the night roar and tumble-climb, the stinking marked bark, the loose-bark fall, and the slow re-climb with filled cheek pouches (per prose cues; not pixel-verified).
- The closing spreads show the storm cling, the dawn clearing with the uncoiling snake, the fast hopping dash, and the final high feeding rest in the good-home tree (per prose cues; not pixel-verified).

Story text transcribed from the embedded text layer (PDF pages 6-26), joined across line breaks. The page-8 spread ("Koala is thirsty...") and the page-25 hurrying panel were read visually against renders on 9 September 2026 (page 7 confirmed illustration-only) and are now part of the story flow above. Front matter, the about page (28) except as noted, and the illustrated index (page 29) are not included as story prose.